

PROJECT KAVACH — WORKSTREAM C

Executive Readout: Meridian FinServe Pvt. Ltd.

Prepared for: Board of Directors **Classification:** Restricted — Board Use Only **Date:** August 2026

What We Found

Finding 1 — A door was left open, and someone walked through it. An attacker was active inside Meridian's internal network for at least 72 hours before this engagement began. They entered through a branch office computer, moved quietly across the internal network, and reached the systems that hold employee identities and passwords. The attacker was still active at the time of assessment.

Finding 2 — The customer database is one web search away from being emptied. The customer-facing website has a flaw that allows anyone on the internet — without logging in — to pull account records by simply changing a number in a web address. All 180,000 customer records, including names, loan details, and financial history, are reachable this way today.

Finding 3 — The two problems are connected, not separate. The network attacker and the website weakness are not independent risks. An attacker who uses the website flaw to steal staff login credentials can immediately use those credentials to access Meridian's internal network. Conversely, an attacker already inside the network can use stolen internal keys to drain the customer database without triggering any login alert. One door opens the other.

What We Recommend

Recommendation 1 — Close the website flaw this week. The customer record exposure requires a targeted code fix estimated at two to three developer days. Until it is fixed, any person with a browser can access every customer account. This is the highest single-point risk in the estate and has a clear, low-cost resolution.

Recommendation 2 — Contain the active attacker before they escalate. The attacker currently inside the network has not yet demonstrated they have taken full control. That window will close. Isolating the affected systems, resetting all internal passwords, and engaging a specialist incident response team should begin within 48 hours — not at the next quarterly review.

Recommendation 3 — Ensure no secret is stored where an attacker can read it. Critical internal keys — the kind that unlock customer data or grant access to cloud storage — were found stored in plain readable text on company servers. Moving these into a protected storage system costs weeks, not months, and would have prevented the worst-case outcome in the scenario described above.

The Ask

Approve an emergency response budget of ₹[X] to engage an incident response team for 30 days.

The two developer fixes can be funded from existing IT budget. The active network attacker cannot be contained by internal IT alone — it requires specialist forensic capability to safely remove the attacker, verify nothing was taken, and confirm the network is clean. That work needs a board mandate and a budget line today.

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